

Discussion and Analysis

Bibliography

Doane, D. (2024) *The INGO Problem: Power, Privilege, and Renewal*. Practical Action Publishing. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.3362/9781788534420>.

Escobar, A. (1995) *Encountering Development: The Making and Unmaking of the Third World*. Princeton, NJ: Daraja Press (Princeton Studies in Culture, Power, History). Available at: <https://go.exlibris.link/zKV0BrSd>.

Snowden, D. and Rancati, A. (2021) *Managing Complexity (and Chaos) in Times of Crisis: A Field Guide for Decision Makers Inspired by the Cynefin Framework*. Luxemburg: Publications Office of the European Union. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.2760/353>.

“Interviewee Funder” (2026).

Discussion and Analysis

Discussion and Analysis

But with such standardization of metrics, one must ask whose stories are being told and how? What knowledge is being valued and what is being left out? What type of information can be measured?

Findings in Relation to the Study Objectives

The findings of this study will be analyzed in relation to the three main themes through the study objectives:

1. How do CVTL staff perceive the effectiveness of mandated reporting tools?
2. How do current reporting mechanisms impose an ordered bias?
3. How do local humanitarian workers navigate the tension between the demand for standardized reporting and the complexity of their lived experiences?

Perceptions of Mandated Reporting Tools

Ordered Bias in Reporting Mechanisms

Navigating the Tension

As it stands, not only is the information that is being reported to donors disconnected from the lived experiences of local humanitarian workers, but these workers are also disenfranchised in the knowledge production process. The standardized reporting mechanisms that are designed to satisfy donor requirements often do not take into account the local knowledge and expertise of local humanitarian workers, and instead prioritize the information that is deemed valuable by donors.

Implications for Practice

The Cynefin framework emphasizes the importance of context in decision-making and problem-solving. An element of contextual awareness is acknowledging the “need to establish meaningful processes of stakeholder engagement beyond user research to make sense of local experiences and build whole ecosystems from the bottom-up” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Furthermore, problem-solving through such “complexity-informed” approaches will find “the answers emerge from the same group who is researching and acting in the landscape” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37). Rather than the affected communities and their local humanitarian workers becoming data and subjects to be known and measured (Escobar, 1995), they are active participants in the process of making sense of their lived experiences and the way this information is used to inform decision-

making and action. This is a shift from the traditional top-down approach to humanitarian aid, where decisions are made by external actors based on standardized data and metrics, to a more participatory and inclusive approach that values local knowledge and experiences. The current approach of “prescription and direction” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) from funding agencies and INGOs, who rely on standardized reporting tools and metrics, continue to place external actors as “holder of the solution” (Snowden and Rancati, 2021, p. 37) with local humanitarians as instruments to be used and communities as problems to be solved, data to be measured, and subjects to be known.

There are already—and have always been—beacons of change working quietly in the sector, overshadowed by the dominant paradigms and giants of this “Humanitarian Industrial Complex” (“Interviewee Funder,” 2026). In contrast to the rigorous reporting requirements of traditional donors and INGOs, there are emerging models of funding and support that prioritize local knowledge, expertise, and power. One interviewee was the founder of a non-profit charity that provides direct funding to local humanitarian organizations in over 70 countries without the requirement of standardized reporting, instead trust is cultivated through relationship-building with these local humanitarians. This founder called out the “limousine liberals”—the industry giants that siphon off funds intended to support work in affected communities. Instead, money is allocated to the overhead costs of these Global North institutions and their staff that parachute into communities for short-term projects. This founder’s accusations are not unwarranted, in fact, the OECD has “finally acknowledged” that “giving through INGOs”— or “fund-emediaries”, as some have dubbed them— “actually costs more” than giving directly to community-based organizations (Doane, 2024, p. 61). The overspending is precisely due to the “inflated international overhead and salary costs” that the founder interviewed called out (Doane, 2024, p. 61). In fact, direct funding to local intermediaries and organizations “can deliver programming that is 32% more cost efficient than [through] international intermediaries” (Doane, 2024, p. 61). So why is money still being funneled through these intermediaries? The legacy of colonial power dynamics and the narratives of mistrust that justify the need for INGOs to act as intermediaries and gatekeepers of knowledge production continue to perpetuate this system, even in the face of evidence that it is not the most effective way to support affected communities. Doane argues that it is the responsibility of these institutions holding privilege to recognize their perpetuation of colonial, racial dynamics and to take active steps to make space for the local humanitarians and the communities served.

Grassroot, “return to culture” (Escobar, 1995, p. 14).